administration was more flexible about granting travel permits, Obama did not restore the educational travel possibilities that had been implemented by Clinton and continued into the first years of the Bush Administration. While Raúl Castro called for talks between the two governments on all topics, with no preconditions, the Obama administration continued to insist that dialogue would be limited unless Cuba carried out internal reforms.

Meanwhile, the global economic downturn and falling prices for Cuban exports compounded natural disasters – two major hurricanes in 2008 – to make 2009 a bleak year economically for Cuba. A survey in March of 2009 concluded that "Cubans struggle to survive from day to day … They are particularly concerned about food shortages and rising prices, and worry that hurricane damage and the global financial crisis will make their situation worse. Many respondents fear that Cuba might be entering another 'Special Period'."[47] A Cuban economic official concurred that Cuba was going through a "very deep and difficult crisis."[48]

By the end of 2009 hopes on both sides of the border for an end to the hostilities were also dimmed. The United States refused to even acknowledge Cuba's key demands that it release the "Cuban Five" imprisoned intelligence officers, that it end the blockade, and cease its attempts, covert and otherwise, to interfere in Cuba's internal affairs. "The Obama honeymoon here is over," declared the *New York Times's* Marc Lacey from Havana at the end of the year, referring to statements by Raúl Castro and others accusing the United States of "open and undercover subversion against Cuba."[49]

Notes

1 "Violenta crítica de Raúl Castro contra académicos y periodistas," *La Jornada* [Mexico], March 28, 1996. www.jornada.unam.mx/1996/03/28/cuba.html.

2 Javier Corrales called 1993–95 "the peak of economic reform." See Corrales, "The Gatekeeper State."